

Report on Women's Education and the Learned Society in the Sangam Period

The Sangam Period (c. 300 BCE - 300 CE) is widely regarded as the Golden Age of ancient Tamil civilization. A defining characteristic of this era was its highly evolved, intellect-driven society where education was not a gender-driven privilege, but a communal virtue. While women in many contemporary global civilizations faced increasing domestic confinement, women in the ancient Tamil country enjoyed remarkable social freedom, literary agency, and intellectual respect.

1. The Pantheon of Women Poets (Perpal Pulavargal)

The most definitive proof of women's literacy and education in the Sangam era is the sheer volume of literature authored by women. Out of the nearly 473 poets identified in the corpus of the Ettutokai (Eight Anthologies) and Patuppattu (Ten Idylls), more than 40 were women. This concentration of female literary voices is unprecedented in ancient global history.

Some of the most prominent women scholars

included:

Anvayiar: A towering intellectual, diplomat, and court poet who wielded immense political influence.

Kakkaipadiniyar: A scholar so well-versed in linguistics that she formulated rules for Tamil grammar and prosody.

Okkoor Masathiyar, Velli Veethiyar, Ponnudiyar, and Angavai-Sangavai: Poets who wrote extensively on diverse themes ranging from raw human psychology to statecraft.

2. Nature and Scope of Women's Education

Education for women during the Sangam era went far beyond basic literacy; it was holistic, focusing on life skills, fine arts, political awareness, and

ethics.

Literary and Philosophical Liberty: Women were fluent in the complex conventions of Akam (interior/love poetry) and Puram (exterior/heroic poetry). They had the social freedom to express their desires, grief, and political critiques publicly.

The Fine Arts (Muthamizh): Education integrated literature, music, and drama. Women belonging to the Panar community (Padinisi) were highly trained in playing complex musical instruments (like the Yagam) and composing oral histories.

Moral Leadership: Women were viewed as the custodians of Aram (righteousness). The mother was recognized as a child's primary educator, responsible for instilling both intellectual curiosity and civic

duty.

3. The Prevalence of a Learned Society Environment

Ancient Tamil Nadu thrived as a meritocratic ecosystem where intellect, wisdom, and poetic brilliance superseded caste, class, or gender. This scholarly atmosphere was sustained by several pillars:

A. Intellectual Sway in Royal Courts

Kings did not merely patronize poets; they treated them as equals and guides. The poet Auvaiyar served as the chief diplomat for King Atthiyaman Neduman Anchi. When a rival king, Thondaiman, prepared to wage war, Atthiyaman sent Auvaiyar as an envoy. She inspected Thondaiman's armory and subtly dismantled his hubris through a brilliant poem, effectively preventing a war. This highlights that educated women held significant geopolitical leverage.

B. The Fusion of Valor and Wisdom

Sangam society balanced a culture of fierce martial honor with deep philosophical grounding. Women were active stakeholders in this dynamic. For instance, a famous poem by Ponnudiyar

outlines the societal duties of education:

"To bring forth and rear a child is my duty; To make him a scholar (Saandron) is the father's duty... To give him a sword and send him to battle is the king's duty."

The term Saandron (a person of noble character and high learning) was the ultimate ideal in Sangam life, and women were the architects of such individuals.

C. Democratic Literary Platforms

The Sangam (assemblies of scholars) created an environment of rigorous peer review and debate. Literary gatherings were not restricted to elite spaces; they happened in town commons (Manram) and festivals. Women participated in these discourses without inhibition. The verses of Velli Veethiyar, for instance, offer raw, psychologically complex portrayals of emotional longing and independence, proving that women were encouraged to think and write individualistically.

Conclusion

The Sangam society, guided by the timeless philosophy of Kaniyan Pungundranar—"Yadum Ore Yaavarum Kelir"

(To us all towns are one, all men our kin)—built an environment where knowledge was universal.

Women's education was not a separate, hard-won concession; it was woven organically into the fabric of ancient Tamil culture. By occupying spaces as poets, political strategists, and moral arbiters, the educated women of the Sangam period helped foster an enlightened, progressive, and balanced society that remains a benchmark for gender equality today.

Development of Scientific Tamil

Scientific Tamil refers to the branch of the Tamil language used to express scientific, technological, medical, and engineering concepts with precision. Since ancient times, Tamils excelled in fields like medicine (Siddha), astronomy, architecture, metallurgy, and agriculture, as evidenced by Sangam literature.

However, the formal development of modern Scientific Tamil, incorporating Western scientific methodologies, gained momentum in the 19th century with the arrival of Europeans and the printing press.

The Early Phase (19th Century): Periodicals like 'Tamil Magazine' (1831) and books like Phenius's 'Bhumi Sastram' (Geography) served as the starting points for taking science to the masses in Tamil.

The Renaissance Phase (20th Century): Scholars like Rajaji, P. N. Appuswami, and Manavai Mustafa laid a strong foundation. This era saw the creation of extensive encyclopedias (Kalaikalangiyam) and domain-specific technical dictionaries.

The Modern/Digital Era: Today, in the digital age,

Scientific Tamil is evolving through online terminology banks, Tamil Wikipedia, and the creation of Tamil-medium engineering and medical textbooks by state universities.

Steps Needed to Improve the Quality of Scientific Tamil

To make Scientific Tamil globally competitive and easily accessible to students, the following steps are essential:

1. Standardized and Simplified Coining of Technical Terms

When creating Tamil equivalents for global scientific terms, the focus should be on clarity and simplicity rather than rigid linguistic purism.

A balanced approach involving Translation (for conceptual terms), Adaptation (modifying terms to suit Tamil phonetics), or Transliteration (retaining international terms like 'Oxygen' or 'Atom' as they are) should be used.

2. Creation of High-Quality Textbooks and Research Journals

State universities (like Anna University) and institutions (like Tanjaver Tamil University) must collaborate to produce world-class engineering and medical textbooks in Tamil.

Steps should be taken to encourage researchers to publish peer-reviewed scientific papers in Tamil, aiming for inclusion in international databases like Scopus or SCJ.

3. Collaboration Between Scientists and Linguists

There must be active institutional collaboration between core scientists/engineers and Tamil language experts/linguists.

This ensures that while the scientific accuracy of a concept remains intact, the sentence structure remains grammatically sound and easy to read.

4. Digitalization and Open-Access Material

A centralized Online Digital Terminology Bank should be created so that students, teachers, and translators can access updated scientific terms instantly.

E-learning platforms, animations, and laboratory demonstration videos should be produced in Tamil to enhance conceptual understanding among students.

5. Popularizing Science in Tamil (Mass Outreach)

Science communication should not be restricted to classrooms. Science magazines, podcasts, and digital media must explain daily scientific advancements in lucid Tamil.

School and college science exhibitions, quiz competitions, and seminars focusing on "Scientific Tamil" should be funded and promoted regularly.

Key Takeaway: For true innovation to happen, conceptual thinking must happen in one's mother tongue. Elevating the quality of Scientific Tamil from a mere translated language into a language of original scientific thought is the ultimate goal.